



Prey: Moon Crash

through progress, they can become so overpowered that they might eventually get bored once they achieve a level of upgrades, making it easy to decimate the enemies.

It is interesting how roguelike games, once tweaked, can assume so many different forms and create so many different game dynamics. It is not just randomness that augments the experience but also the designer's approach and creativity that can significantly make it stand out in keeping the gameplay fresh. This is one of the sole reasons why we see more games relying on RNG and Progen from indie devs than Triple-A studios. Indie studios tend to have off the wall ideas and take their development in unconventional areas to stand out. Depending on roguelikes has become a staple formula to stand out in a highly saturated market of games with hundreds, if not thousands of titles released every day.

What is also intriguing is that there have been games that take inspiration

from roguelike principles but don't follow it completely. Let's say, as a developer, you wanted your target audience to experience a fantastic hand-crafted level but still wanted replayability. Mooncrash, the DLC to Prey, does just that. It takes place in an infinitely repeating simulation of a lunar base. The only way to stop the simulation is for each of the 5 characters to explore, track down and use all the escape methods within the same loop. This would have been very stale and uninteresting to play because over multiple runs, the player would have eventually figured out the exact method to escape and complete the simulation and probably never touch the DLC again. However, the developers put an insane twist to the simulation. Many smaller elements are randomised in different runs but significantly impact the overall gameplay. It bends the rules of random dungeon generation and perma-death to make its experience rather unique. The game keeps on changing the environmental hazards, locations

of items and enemies, the architecture (which may cause certain areas to be inaccessible). Gaining familiarity with the lunar base becomes an important facet of completing the simulation but not in a way that can make the gameplay stale. The player must improvise and think on their feet each run because an escape route might not work in one run, or environmental hazards can make a shortcut inaccessible, continuously derailing plans. It has a more rogue-lite stance on the idea of perma-death, providing permanent upgrades between different runs. However, the game keeps on ramping up the difficulty with the player's skill and upgrades, keeping things spicy for them.

## Conclusion

The world of video game development will always be filled with exciting ways to immerse gamers into crazy experiences. While the big-budget titles will mostly opt for content that is controlled and tailored to their wish, indie game development will always pave the way with unconventional design choices and wield the metaphorical staff of RNGesus and generate unique experiences. They do not rely on well-designed models, expansive storylines, or a million side quests, and will instead rely on simple ideas which are executed brilliantly with smart design and programming to generate unique adventures. One that players can claim only happened with them and no one else. The ravine next to a mountainside facing a vast ocean where someone built a Japanese style mansion in MineCraft, the broken Dead Cells run where every single weapon stacked and compounded bleeding, the desolate planet in No Man's Sky with a million monolithic structures looking like a fallen futuristic society, these are all incredibly beautiful capsules of experiences which are only possible by the power of randomness. This is the one aspect of video games as an entire industry that is exclusively found in only indie projects. And it is truly breathtaking. \*



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